CONTRASTING NARRATIVES OF DEMOCRATIZATION

Western donor agencies

In considering narratives of democratization and the new rift between the Western aid community and democracy movement, it is crucial the spotlight of investigation does not only fall on one side. Studies by Walton and Hayward (2013) and Kyaw San Wai (2014) have made valuable efforts to outline Burmese Buddhist perspectives and underlying reasoning which informs reactions to communal violence. Yet the arguments put forward by Western actors are less commonly unpacked. Therefore, in this section I begin by outlining a perspective on communal violence in Myanmar — and its grounding in wider assumptions about democratization — which is common among international aid workers. Of course, there is diversity between different Western actors and agencies, so there needs to be some caution about essentialising a uniquely "Western" position. Narratives here are treated as "decentred" — in the sense that there is no single or homogenous way individuals relate the story.[4]

The study revealed that many international aid workers were surprised and dismayed at the reactions of leaders in the opposition movement to news of incidents of violence in Meiktila or Rakhine State. Michael,[5] a European donor representative, described Aung San Suu Kyi's BBC interview as "deeply disappointing" (Interview 37, 2014 English), suggesting she was making a calculated political choice to refrain from condemning the violence. Meanwhile, Claire, an aid agency manager, was concerned about the way the public had responded, not only to violence against Rohingya, but also the wider hostility toward Muslims. She said, "When it was just the Rohingya … you felt here is this one group that people are just mental about. But then when Meiktila happened ... It was brutal and totally shocking" (Interview 17, 2013 English).

Thus in some ways, the explanations of aid workers reflected international media portrayals of prominent Burmese opposition leaders and activists as "mental", or in the case of Aung San Suu Kyi, insincere. Yet concern was also directed not only toward leaders, but also toward Bamar aid workers within their own, or partner, organisations.[6] Thomas, an international agency director said, "I have no idea how many times my head office is saying 'something is happening in Rakhine [regarding